Reported speech: statements

Goal: To report what a famous person said or wrote without quoting the exact words, by changing the tense, the pronouns and the time expressions correctly (reported statements only).

The idea in two lines: Direct speech repeats the exact words between quotation marks. Reported speech tells the same message with *said (that)* or *told + person (that)*; when the reporting verb is in the past, the verb inside moves "one step back" into the past.

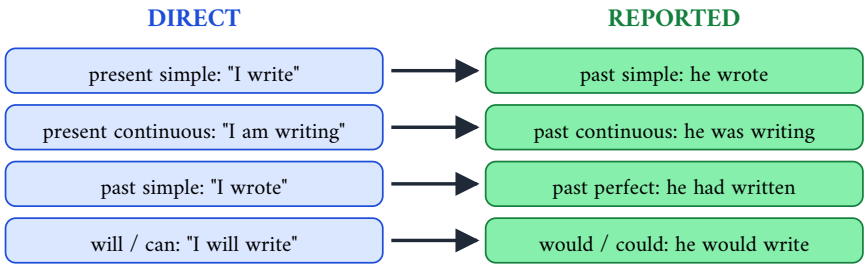


Figure 1: The "one step back" rule: each tense in direct speech moves to a more past tense in reported speech.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Reporting verbs:** *say* has no object (*She said that...*); *tell* needs a person (*She told me that...*). *That* can be left out.
2. **Tense change (backshift):** present simple → past simple; present continuous → past continuous; past simple / present perfect → past perfect; *will* → *would*; *can* → *could*; *must* → *had to*.
3. **Pronouns** change to fit the speaker: *I* → *he / she*; *we* → *they*; *my* → *his / her*; *you* → *me / us / them* depending on the listener.
4. **Time and place words** move away from "now": *today* → *that day*; *tomorrow* → *the next / following day*; *yesterday* → *the day before*; *now* → *then*; *here* → *there*; *this* → *that*.
5. If the reporting verb is in the **present** (*He says that...*), there is no tense change.

6. Quotation marks, the capital letter and the final full stop of the quoted sentence disappear; the reported clause is a normal statement, not a question.

🟢 Examples

1. Direct: The writer said, "I love my country and I write about its people." **Solution:** The writer said that he loved his country and he wrote about its people. **Explanation:** *I* → *he*, *my* → *his*, present simple → past simple.
2. Direct: "I will visit the museum tomorrow," Amina told us. **Solution:** Amina told us that she would visit the museum the following day. **Explanation:** *will* → *would*; *tomorrow* → *the following day*.
3. Direct: "We finished the project yesterday," the pupils said. **Solution:** The pupils said that they had finished the project the day before.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Writing *She said me that* ×: use *She told me that* or *She said to me that*.
- Forgetting to change the pronoun: *He said that I was tired* when the speaker was talking about himself × → *he was tired* ✓.
- Keeping the quotation marks or the question-word order in the reported sentence.
- Changing the tense when the reporting verb is in the present (*He says that he lives in Oran*, not *lived*).

🟡 Quick review

- said (that) / told + person (that).
- One step back: present → past; past → past perfect; will → would; can → could.
- I → he/she, we → they, my → his/her.
- now → then, today → that day, tomorrow → the next day, here → there.
- No quotation marks, no tense change after a present reporting verb.

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